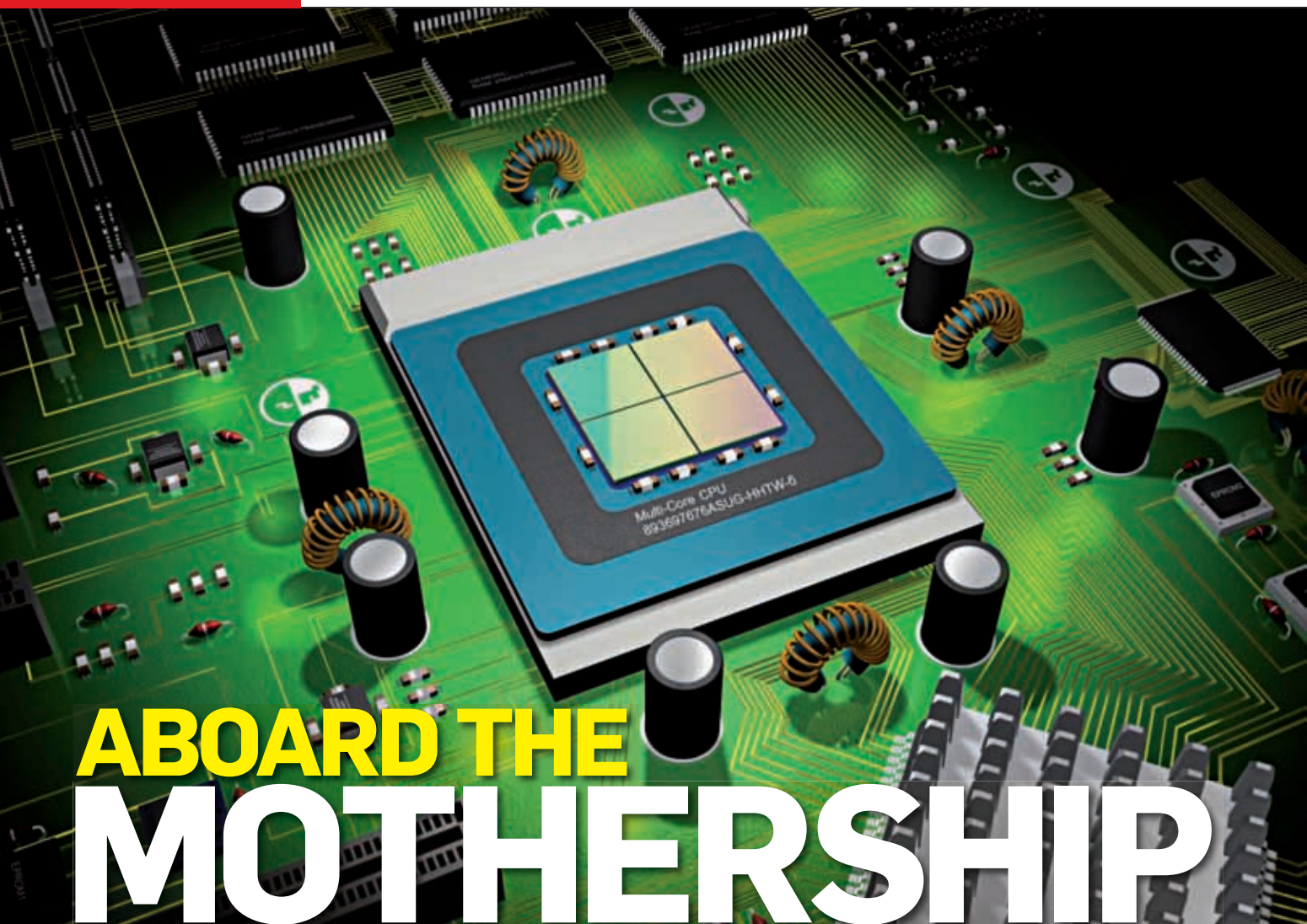




ABOARD THE MOTHERSHIP

Choosing the right motherboard for your system is an arduous task, specially with so many brands and chipsets to contend with. We make that task easier for you by testing over 30 boards (both Z68 and A75 chipset based)

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“What motherboard should I buy?” is one of the most common questions our readers ask us. Within motherboards, there are so many levels to consider that without proper guidance it's very difficult to pin down a specific board.

This year saw the entry of Intel's Sandy Bridge motherboards with the P67 and H67 chipsets, which Digit com-

pared back in January. The Z68 chipset was launched in May and more recently, the A75 chipset was introduced by AMD. We decided to do a shootout of boards based on these two chipsets. You can expect a similar shootout of higher end chipsets, namely AMDs 990FX (already in the market) and Intel's X79 (to be launched later this year) sometime next year. Needless to say, the Z68 and A75 are two completely different chipsets and boards housing these chipsets are not comparable. For this precise reason,

even though we've tested both these chipsets, they should be considered as two separate comparison tests.

Z68 Boards ₹20,000 and up

A category of boards that is overkill for most users, but there's a definite demand for such boards. It's all about overclocking and tweaking and of course the looks. We got three boards which were priced well over ₹20,000 namely, the Gigabyte Z68X-UD7-B3, ASUS Maximus IV Extreme Z and Gigabyte G1 Sniper 2.

G1 Sniper2 is the LGA1155 iteration of the original G1 Sniper which was available on the LGA1366 socket for the X58 chipset. The packaging of the board and the board itself command attention. A metallic bullet magazine acts as the heatsink for the southbridge and has a cheeky warning, “Not a weapon, cannot be assembled as a firearm.” The heatsink in the centre has five LEDs that glow green when the board is powered on.

The G1 Sniper 2 has features such as an on-board BigFoot Killer E2100 NIC and Creative